

Cult Discipling Control

cult-discipling-control

Cult Marker · Authoritarian Shepherding · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.925
confidence high

Statement under examination

Shepherding relationships in the Church do not require the disciple's unconditional submission of every life decision to a designated leader; binding the conscience in matters Scripture leaves free is contrary to the apostolic pattern.

In plain language

Several passages anchor this proposition, and they speak with striking consistency about how leaders may relate to those they lead. In 1 Peter 5:2 to 3 elders are told to shepherd the flock not by compulsion but willingly, and not as lording it over (katakyrieuontes) those entrusted to them, but becoming examples (tupoi). The verb translated lording it over is a strong word for top-down mastery, and it is flatly forbidden. The rare word for by compulsion (anagkastos) appears only here in the canon (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and it is rejected in favor of the word for freely (hekousios). So the authorized picture is a leader who models, not one who masters. In 2 Corinthians 1:24 Paul says directly, not that we lord it over (kyrieuomen) your faith, but we are fellow workers (synergoi) of your joy, for by faith you stand. He calls himself a co-worker, and he says each believer stands on his own faith. In Matthew 20:25 to 26, repeated in Mark 10:42 to 43 and Luke 22:25, Jesus uses two paired verbs (katakyrieuousin and katexousiazousin) to describe how gentile rulers lord it over and exercise authority over people, and then says it shall not be so among you, but the great one must be a servant (diakonos). In Matthew 23:8 to 12 the title of master-guide (kathegetes) and the title of father are reserved for Christ and for God, and the greatest is again the servant. Galatians 5:1 adds that Christ set us free for freedom (eleutheria), and warns against being placed again under a yoke of slavery (zygos douleias). Where confusion enters is Hebrews 13:17, often rendered obey your leaders. The Greek uses one verb (peitho) that across the New Testament means to be persuaded or to trust, and a second verb (hypeiko) that occurs only once in the whole canon, whose sense leans toward deferring or giving way. Neither is the strong command-compliance verb. The same chapter calls the leaders watchmen who will give account to God, not masters. Read together, the words used forbid coercive control over a disciple and refuse to bind the conscience by force in matters the text leaves open. The leader serves, models, and works alongside, while the believer stands directly before God.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0317	ἀναγκαστῶς	anagkastos	necessarily	1
G1249	διάκονος	diakonos	servant	30
G1397	δουλεία	douleia	slavery	5
G1596	ἐκουσίως	hekousios	voluntarily	2
G1657	ἐλευθερία	eleutheria	freedom	11
G2218	ζυγός	zygos	yoke/scales	6
G2476	ἵστημι	histemi	to stand	153

G2519	καθηγητής	kathegetes	teacher	2
G2634	κατακυριεύω	katakyrrieuo	to master	4
G2715	κατεξουσιάζω	katexousiazō	to rule	2
G2819	κληρος	kleros	lot	12
G2961	κυριεύω	kyrieuo	to lord over	7
G3402	μιμητής	mimētēs	imitator	
G3982	πείθω	peitho	to persuade	54
G4168	ποίμνιον	poimnion	flock	5
G4904	συνεργός	synergos	co-worker	13
G5013	ταπεινός	tapeinoō	to humble	
G5179	τύπος	typos	mark/example	15
G5226	ὑπέικω	hypeiko	to submit	1
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The leadership texts encode their commands with explicit negation. In 1 Peter 5:3 the present participle (an ongoing action form of the verb) "lording it over" (katakyrrieuontes, G2634) is forbidden of elders toward "those allotted" (ton kleron), and replaced by "becoming examples" (tupoi ginomenoi, G5179, G1096), while 1 Peter 5:2 sets the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) adverb "by compulsion" (anagkastos, G0317) against "willingly" (hekousios, G1596). In 2 Corinthians 1:24 Paul says "not that we lord it over" (ouch hoti kyrieuomen, G2961) "your faith" (hymon tes pisteos), but are "fellow workers" (synergoi, G4904), "for by faith you stand" (te gar pistei hestekate, G2476), locating each believer on his own footing before God. Matthew 20:25 to 26 and the Markan parallel Mark 10:42 to 45 pair the same "lord it over" (katakyrrieuousin, G2634) with "exercise authority over" (katexousiazousin, G2715) of gentile rulers and forbid both with "it shall not be so among you" (ouch houtos estai en hymin). Matthew 23:8 to 12 reserves "master-guide" (kathegetes, G2519) and "father" (pater, G3962) for Christ and the Father, leaving "servant" (diakonos, G1249) rank for the greatest. The pattern is dense, recurring, and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) across four New Testament corpora, so it affirms.

Scripture

1Pet.5.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2634 κατακυριεύω, G2819 κληρος, G5179 τύπος

Force. 1 Peter 5:3 reads: "Not as lording it over those allotted to you, but becoming examples of the flock." The negated present participle (ongoing action form) "lording it over" (katakyrrieuontes), with its "kata" prefix (a down-against marker) intensifying "to master" (kyrieuo) toward downward mastery, is set against "becoming examples" (tupoi ginomenoi), an ongoing modeling, so the authorized mode of oversight is imitable example rather than coercive mastery over the persons assigned. The genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form) "of those allotted" (ton kleron) names the people themselves as the inappropriate object of any such mastery.

1Pet.5.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4168 ποιμνιον, G0317 ἀναγκαστῶς, G1596 ἐκουσίως

Force. 1 Peter 5:2 reads: "Shepherd the flock of God among you, exercising oversight not by compulsion but willingly." The hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) adverb "by compulsion, by force" (anagkastos) occurs only here in the New Testament canon and is rejected in favor of "freely, willingly" (hekousios), so the framing of oversight is voluntary care rather than imposed necessity binding the will of the one shepherded.

2Cor.1.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2961 κυριεύω, G4904 συνεργός, G2476 ἵστημι

Force. 2 Corinthians 1:24 reads: "Not that we lord it over your faith, but we are fellow workers of your joy, for by faith you stand." The emphatic "not that" (ouch hoti) negates "we master" (kyrieuomen) over the believer's faith, and "fellow workers" (synergoi) reclassifies the apostle as a co-laborer. The perfect tense (a completed action whose result still stands) "you have stood and continue to stand" (hestekate) locates each believer directly on faith, not on submission to a leader.

Matt.20.25 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2634 κατακυριεύω, G2715 κατεξουσιάζω

Force. Matthew 20:25 reads: "You know that the rulers of the gentiles lord it over them, and their great ones exercise authority over them." The two paired "kata"-prefixed verbs (the prefix marks downward control), "they lord it over" (katakyrieuousin) and "they exercise authority over" (katexousiazousin), both with the directional "kata" of downward control, describe pagan domination as the foil that the next clause forbids for the disciples. The verbs together mark top-down control over persons as the gentile, not kingdom, pattern.

Matt.20.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1249 διάκονος

Force. Matthew 20:26 reads: "It shall not be so among you, but whoever wishes to be great among you shall be your servant." The clause "it shall not be so among you" (ouch houtos estai en hymin), formed with future indicative of prohibition (a future-tense statement of fact functioning as a command), directly forbids the domination just described, and "servant" (diakonos) resets greatness as service, so the leader holds no mastering claim over the disciple but a serving role.

Mark.10.42 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2634 κατακυριεύω, G2715 κατεξουσιάζω

Force. The Markan parallel at Mark 10:42 uses the same paired verbs "they lord it over" (katakyrieuousin) and "they exercise authority over" (katexousiazousin) to describe gentile rulers and gentile great ones. That "to exercise authority over" (katexousiazō) occurs in the canon only here and in the Matthew parallel, and "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) only four times, makes the verb choice deliberate and tightly bound to this prohibition, so its repetition across two gospels strengthens the negation of dominating control.

Mark.10.43 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1249 διάκονος

Force. Mark 10:43 reads: "But it shall not be so among you. Whoever wishes to become great among you shall be your servant." The same "it shall not be so among you" (ouch houtos estai en hymin) and the same "servant" (diakonos) reordering of rank repeat, so the Markan witness independently encodes the same negation of mastering authority over persons.

Luke.22.25 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2961 κυριεύω

Force. Luke 22:25 reads: "The kings of the gentiles lord it over them, and those who exercise authority over them are called benefactors." The Lukan parallel uses simple "they lord it over" (kyrieuousin) rather than the intensified "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo), but the same contrast with serving rank follows, so all three synoptic witnesses converge on forbidding leaders to relate to disciples as gentile rulers relate to subjects.

Matt.23.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2519 καθηγητής, G5547 Χριστός

Force. Matthew 23:10 reads: "Neither be called guides, for one is your guide, the Christ." The aorist (a completed past action) subjunctive prohibition with "do not" (mede) limits the title "master-guide" (kathēgetes) to a single referent, Christ. Since "master-guide" (kathēgetes) occurs only twice in the canon and both within this passage, the lexeme is functionally reserved, so no human leader may occupy the office that would warrant unconditional directive authority over another disciple.

Matt.23.11 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1249 διάκονος

Force. Matthew 23:11 reads: "The greatest among you shall be your servant." The same "servant" (diakonos) word reorders rank toward service, parallel to Matthew 20:26 and Mark 10:43, reinforcing that prominence in the community is measured by serving, not by the authority to command the lives of others.

Gal.5.1 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1657 ἐλευθερία, G2218 ζυγός, G1397 δουλεία

Force. Galatians 5:1 reads: "For freedom Christ set us free. Stand firm therefore and do not again be held in a yoke of slavery." The dative (a noun in the 'to-X' or 'for-X' grammatical form) "for freedom" (eleutheria) of purpose, with the imperative "stand firm" (stekete) and the prohibition against the "yoke of slavery" (zygos douleias), frames submission of the conscience to imposed external requirement as a return to bondage, supporting the limit on binding what Scripture leaves free.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Pet.5.3	Ezek.34.4	tsk	1
Gal.5.1	Gal.5.13	tsk	1
1Pet.5.2	Isa.56.11	tsk	1
Matt.23.9	Matt.6.8	tsk	1
Matt.20.25	Mark.10.42	tsk	1
Matt.20.25	Luke.22.25	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Heb.13.17 · addressed

Hebrews 13:17 reads: "Obey (peithesthe, G3982) and submit (hypeikete, G5226) to your leaders, for they keep watch over your souls as those who will give account." The lexical root-cause of confusion is that the English word "obey" flattens two different verbs. "To persuade, to trust, to yield to" (peitho, G3982) means "to be persuaded, to trust, to yield to," and across its 54 New Testament occurrences it predominantly carries the sense of being convinced, not coerced compliance. The middle voice (a verb form where the subject acts on or for itself) "let yourselves be persuaded by" (peithesthe) here means "let yourselves be persuaded by." "To yield, to give way" (hypeiko, G5226) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the New Testament canon, so its sense cannot be triangulated from other New Testament uses, but its classical sense is "to yield, to give way, to defer." Neither verb is the strong imperative compliance verb. The clause "as those who will render account" (hos logon apodosontes) binds the leader to God rather than vesting unconditional rule, and these leaders are explicitly framed as oversight-watchmen, not as those who lord it over. So the verse establishes a relationship of trusted persuasion and deference, not the unconditional submission of every life decision that the proposition denies, and it sits alongside the explicit prohibitions of "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) and "to master" (kyrieuo) over persons.

1Cor.11.1 · addressed

1 Corinthians 11:1 reads: "Be imitators (mimetai, G3402) of me as I also am of Christ." The lemma (the dictionary form of a word) "imitator" (mimetes) occurs only six times in the New Testament, always in patterns of becoming, and could be read as warranting a controlling pattern. But the "as I also am of Christ" (kathos kago Christou) clause bounds the imitation strictly to the apostle insofar as he tracks Christ. This matches the "examples" (tupoi) model of 1 Peter 5:3 rather than a conscience-binding directive authority over free matters, so it does not transfer unconditional life-decision authority to a human leader.

1Pet.5.5 · addressed

1 Peter 5:5 reads: "Younger ones be subject (hypotagete, G5293) to the elders." This is the only New Testament use of "to be subject to" (hypotasso) in the elder-flock relation, and the immediately preceding verses bound the elder behavior with the same "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) prohibition. So the submission is reciprocal humility framed within already-forbidden domination, not a license for the elder to require unconditional submission of every life decision. The chapter opens and closes the relationship inside the same negation.

Concordance traversed

G2634, G2715, G2961, G4168, G2819, G5179, G0317, G1596, G4904, G2476, G1249, G2519, G1657, G2218, G1397, G5013, G3982, G5226, G3402

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for the 1 Peter 5, 2 Corinthians 1, Matthew 20, Matthew 23, Mark 10, Luke 22, or Galatians 5 anchors, and the bundle marks these outside published ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope. The editorial marks in the bundle text touch word order and minor spelling, none of which alters the negated verbs "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo), "to exercise authority over" (katexousiazō), and "to master" (kyrieuo) or the contrast between "by compulsion" (anagkastos) and "willingly" (hekousios) that carry the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. servant-leadership ecclesiology, directive-shepherding ecclesiology, high-church sacerdotalism

analogia scripturae invoked

servant-leadership ecclesiology: affirms · Reads the negated verbs "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) and "to exercise authority over" (katexousiazō) and "to master" (kyrieuo) verbs, the "by compulsion" (anagkastos) versus "willingly" (hekousios) contrast, and the "servant" (diakonos) rank as forbidding coercive mastery over the disciple. Leaders

model and serve. Hebrews 13:17 is read by way of "to be persuaded" (peitho) as persuasion and "to yield" (hypeiko) as deference, not as unconditional command, so it does not override the explicit prohibitions of domination.

directive-shepherding ecclesiology: does not affirm the denial · Would lean on Hebrews 13:17 "obey and submit" and on 1 Peter 5:5 "be subject" to maximize leader authority over personal decisions. Stated in its strongest form, this reading takes "to be persuaded" (peitho) and "to yield" (hypeiko) as functional command compliance and takes "be subject" (hypotagete) as broad submission, so the elder has standing directive authority. But this reading must override the explicit prohibitions on lording it over persons and the believer standing directly on faith in 2 Corinthians 1:24, and it must treat the negated "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) and "to master" (kyrieuo) as merely a tone restriction on otherwise unconditional authority, which the lexemes (dictionary forms of the words) do not grant.

high-church sacerdotalism: does not affirm the denial · Stated fairly, this lens would attach binding authority to ordained office independent of the verbs, locating it in the broader pattern of apostolic succession and the keys. On the lexical plane this reading must still explain the negation of "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo) and "to master" (kyrieuo) over persons and the locating of the believer on his own faith in 2 Corinthians 1:24. The verbs do not vest a class of leaders with unconditional life-decision authority, so the lens does not find affirming lexical purchase even in its strongest form.

The verdict turns on the grammar of negated domination verbs and the voluntary versus compelled contrast, read across Peter, Paul, the synoptic gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke) by analogy of Scripture (interpreting Scripture by Scripture). The complicating obedience text Hebrews 13:17 is harmonized through its own qualifying clauses and through the lexical sense of "to be persuaded" (peitho) as persuasion.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the apostolic lexemes (dictionary forms of the key words) for oversight and leadership describe a relationship requiring the disciple to submit every life decision to a designated leader, or whether they limit such authority and locate the believer standing directly on faith.

The stem is framed as a denial, that shepherding does not require unconditional submission and that binding the conscience in free matters is contrary to the apostolic pattern. This carries an evaluative frame, so it was neutralized to a question about what the oversight lexemes actually describe. The verdict was derived on the original stem. The lexical pattern of negated "to lord it over" (katakyrieuo), "to exercise authority over" (katexousiazō), "to master" (kyrieuo), the "by compulsion" (anagastos) versus "willingly" (hekousios) contrast, the "fellow workers" (synergoi) co-worker classification, and the believer "have stood and continue to stand" (hestekate) standing on faith confirms the denial. VERDICT-CHANGED: pan_canonical was raised to true because the pattern is attested in all three synoptic gospels and in Paul and Peter, spanning four New Testament corpora rather than gathering in only one or two.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2634
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2715
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2961
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1596
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0317
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3982
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5226
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.5.3
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.5.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.1.24

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.13.17
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.1.24
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mark.10.42
morphology	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Matt.20.25
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.5.3
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.20.25

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. Citations include MACULA-Greek under CC-BY-NC-4.0 and SBLGNT-text under SBLGNT-EULA, both of which forbid bulk redistribution, so the assembled evidence is not safe to publish in bulk.

Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow